HOW WE TESTED

Initial setup: All Mini-PCs were assembled and the same hardware was used where ever possible. We used Kingston's Impact RAM clocked at the highest any Mini-PC would allow. The DIMMs themselves were capable of going all the way to 1866 MHz. For the SSD we used the ZOTAC Premium Edition 240 GB so as to maintain a level playing field. The LIVA Core comes pre-installed with an Intel 535 Series M.2 SSD, so we let that be. We then installed Windows 10, all drivers and essential software along with the requisite benchmarking software were installed. We then proceeded to install all Windows updates and set the *Windows Power Plan* to a custom *High-Performance* preset.

During the assembly phase, we took at look at the internals to assess the build quality of each competitor.

Performance tests: Our benchmark software suite consists mostly of industry standard tools like PCMark8, 3DMark 8, Cinebench, POVRay etc. We also throw in a few storage benchmarks, like ATTO and WinRaR. While we did use the same hardware for all Mini-PCs, the storage test was basically used to re-affirm that the assembly was done and all storage devices were performing equally across all Mini-PCs.

Features score: The features that were unique to each Mini-PC garnered it the same weightage as any other. This ensures that having something unique did not propel any device to such an extent that the others couldn't catch up.

Build quality: The metrics that we observe are largely based on what we've seen before and that makes build quality a subjective score. However, the parameters are still based on common sense.

Final score: The final score that we arrive at in the performance tests is what decides which Mini-PC becomes the *Best Performer*.

The feature score is used to aid in picking the best buy, so the device with the highest performance/rupee ratio clubbed with the feature score gets to be the *Best Buy*.

The *Editor's Pick* is awarded to whichever device that we feel has narrowly missed out on either the Best Performer or the Best Buy. This does make it a little subjective but the scoring mechanism is largely rooted in how the device scores overall.

VERDICT

The *Best Performer Award* goes to the **Gigabyte Brix GB-BXi5H-5200**. It really was the processor that pushed this little beast ahead of the competition. Club that with a really good build quality and you've got a winning formula. This does come at a price through, and you need to pay a lot more if you want to the RAM and hard drive included. Swapping it out for an SSD to get the extra edge pushes the cost ever further into the mid 40K. But you really do get your money's worth of performance with the Gigabyte Brix GB-BXi5H-5200.

The *Best Buy Award* goes to the **ASRock Beebox N3150**. This nifty little device packs in top of the mill features in the budget category which makes it an attractive option. The fact that it performs quite well for the tasks that it was designed to only works in its favour. For less than ₹10,000 there can hardly be a better option. However, the MSI Cubi which very narrowly missed out on this award is also equally good and a little cheaper. So if three display connectors and a USB Type-C don't tickle your fancy, you best go with the MSI Cubi.

The *Editor's Pick Award* goes to the **ECS LIVA Core** and that too for quite a lot of reasons. Firstly, none of the others come anywhere close in terms of build quality. And it's process is the second best performing in our test so you aren't exactly making a compromise there either. And it even has a MicroSD slot and a high current always on USB 3.0 port makes it an all-rounder of sorts.

While this was a fairly small comparison, the Mini-PC category is bursting at the seams and you'll soon see a lot more reviews coming your way in the coming months.

ASROCK
Beebox N3150
Price - ₹9,649

PROS:
- Value for money
- Multimedia Remote
- USB Type-C

CONS:
- Moderate build quality
- Glossy finish prone to scratches

GIGABYTE
Brix GB-BXi5H-5200
Price - ₹27,299

PROS:
- High performing CPU
- Moderately clocked IGP
- Actively cooled heat-sink

CONS:
- Could have better placement of ports

ECS
LIVA Core
Price - ₹34,499

PROS:
- Low power SoC
- Excellent build quality
- Effective passive heatsink

CONS:
- Low graphics performance
- Lack of availability